



Depiction of the Battle of Agnadello, one of the major battles of the Italian Wars, from the tomb of Louis XII and Anne of Brittany, France.



This detail shows the coronation of Ottoman Sultan Selim I. The empire almost trebled during his nine-year reign.

“ARE THEY NOT MEN? DO THEY NOT HAVE RATIONAL SOULS?”

Antonio de Montesinos, Dominican friar, delivering a sermon to Spanish colonists, Hispaniola, December 4, 1511

Antonio de Montesinos, in which, to predictable outrage, he denounced the “cruelty and tyranny” of the settlers.

Similarly aggressive Spanish and Portuguese attempts at colonization in **Morocco**, where both seized coastal strongholds in the 15th and early 16th centuries, partly helped the rise of a new Moroccan dynasty after 1511—the **Sa’dis**—who filled the political vacuum created by the crumbling of Marinid rule in the 1480s.

The **Venetian Republic** was diplomatically isolated and opposed by almost every major Western European power when

Pope Julius II established the **League of Cambrai** in 1508. The Republic was quickly plunged into crisis by its defeat in May 1509 by Louis XII’s French army at the **Battle of Agnadello**, one of the major battles of the **Italian Wars** (1494–1559). The following year Julius II allied himself with Venice against France, anxious that Venetian territorial designs in northern Italy had been replaced by identical French ambitions. This shuffling of alliances was typical of the period. It was given a further twist with the formation in 1511 of a new **Holy League**, including England, now directed against France. One outcome of this was a subsequent Franco-Venetian alliance.

Hemmed in on the west by the **Ottomans** and threatened to the south by the Portuguese, the **Safavids** were nonetheless successful in confronting the loose **Uzbek confederation** of peoples of Central Asia to their north. In December 1510, with victory over the Uzbeks outside the city of Merv, substantial territories, including Herat, Bactria, and Kandahar, came under **Safavid** rule.

NO LESS SIGNIFICANT than the Spanish exploration of the Caribbean in the immediate aftermath of Columbus’s 1492 crossing was the discovery by **Juan Ponce de León** in April 1513 of the “island” of Florida. It was the first Spanish contact with the mainland of North America and the basis for subsequent Spanish claims to the region. In attempting to circumnavigate his island, Ponce de León made a further discovery almost as important in the age of sail as Columbus’s discovery of the wind systems of the central Atlantic—the **Gulf Stream**.

Niccolò Machiavelli was a diplomat in Florence when, in 1513, he wrote the first modern handbook of political science, *The Prince* (published in 1532). Its central theme—that the exercise of political power requires violence and deceit—earned it lasting notoriety. It offers advice about the most effective means of ruling: essentially a pragmatic determination to use all means at hand.

Ottoman territorial expansion was renewed after the civil war of 1509–12 which saw **Selim I** emerge as sultan at the expense of both his father, Bayezid II, who was forced to abdicate, and Selim’s older brother, Ahmed, who was killed in battle. Selim initiated this burst of growth—directed south and east against fellow Muslims rather than north against Christian Europe—in 1514 when the Safavids, vastly outnumbered and with no answer to the Ottoman

artillery, were overpowered at the Battle of Caldiran. His Eastern flank secured, Selim swept into **Syria** and **Mamluk Egypt**, which instantly crumbled. Selim I not only dramatically increased Ottoman territories but, in securing almost all the Muslim holy places of the Near East, added substantially to Ottoman prestige (see pp.230–31).



NICCOLÒ MACHIAVELLI
(1469–1527)

Philosopher and writer, Niccolò Machiavelli was a functionary in Florence, where he witnessed the power of aggressive rulers first hand, including, in 1502–03, that of the pope’s illegitimate son, the ruthless Cesare Borgia. He completed several diplomatic missions, but in 1513 was arrested and tortured. He wrote *The Prince* in the same year. He died aged of 58, impoverished, before his book enjoyed its later notoriety.



Spice Islands exploration

Portuguese explorer Francisco Serrão successfully reached the Moluccas (Spice Islands) after others had turned back.

KEY

- Antonio de Abreu / Francisco Rodrigues 1512
- Francisco Serrão 1512

December 4, 1511
Antonio de Montesinos
denounces Spanish
colonists over
enslavement

April 11, 1512 French
defeat Holy League at
Ravenna, Italy

1512 Portuguese
reach **Spice**
Islands

1512 Accession of
Selim I in Ottoman
Empire

1512 Songhay
Empire of West
Africa conquers
Hausa states of
Katsina, Zaria, and
Kano

1513 Spanish explorer
Juan Ponce de León
claims Florida coast
for Spain

September 13, 1515
Battle of Marignano in
northern Italy leaves
French in control of
Duchy of Milan

1514 Ottomans crush
Safavids at Caldiran in
northwest Iran and
overrun Syria

1515 Babur
(1483–1531)
conquers Punjab
and occupies
Delhi, India

1515 Alliance between
Habsburg and Polish
Jagellon dynasties in
Central Europe